Chiefs' Founder, Owner Succumbs To Cancer

By Tracy Allen
CALL Staff Writer

Lamar Hunt's legacy in bringing along the National Football League can never be ignored, even by those of the old establishment who weren't fans of the old American Football League.

LAMAR HUNT

A man who knew the power that bridging of the American Football and National Football leagues could bring to the sport, will be remembered in the days ahead as the mastermind that created what is now known as one of the most watched and emulated professional sports leagues in the world.

Late Wednesday evening at 10 p.m., the Kansas City Chiefs founder and owner, who left an indelible mark on professional sports, died at Presbyterian hospital in Dallas of prostate cancer. Hunt was 74.

Hunt was admitted to the Dallas hospital on Thanksgiving after suffering through complications with cancer medication and a collapsed lung. Hunt wasn't able to watch in person his Chiefs' play the inaugural game that was televised on the NFL Network, but he was remembered and spoken about frequently by all in attendance of that Kansas City-Denver contest.

In a statement released by his son, Clark Hunt, who will now resume leadership of the Chiefs fran-

Continued on page 4

Chiefs Founder Continued from front page

chise, he simply stated, "my father, Lamar Hunt, went to be with the Lord."

Hunt leaves behind his wife, Norma, children, Sharron Munson, Lamar Jr., Clark , and Daniel, and a host of grandchildren.

Kansas City Mayor Kay Barnes has ordered that flags on all City buildings be lowered to half staff today, Friday, Dec. 15 through Tuesday, Dec.19, in memory of two Kansas City icons who have passed away in the last few days, Hunt and jazz great Jay McShann. McShann, who was given tributes on Thursday, and will have funeral services on Saturday, at 2 p.m., at Watkins Brothers Memorial Chapel, died Thursday, Dec. 7, at St. Luke's hospital. McShann was 90.

On Thursday, Mayor Barnes said, "Lamar Hunt's contributions to Kansas City have been vast and will stand for decades to come. Though Kansas City was not his permanent residence, Lamar was probably the best-known honorary Kansas Citian in the world. In bringing world-class sports franchises to Kansas City, Lamar has brought immeasurable attention to our city and given us a sense of pride and dignity in our community.

"Lamar was a brilliant and creative businessman, but also a charming, kind and welcoming person. I know he loved Kansas City and wanted to see it thrive and prosper, and Kansas City is certainly a better place because of Lamar Hunt. This community will miss him greatly. There are very few individuals whose contributions have had or will have such a lasting positive influence on our community."

Stated Mayor Barnes, "On behalf of the entire community, I extend my sincere condolences to Lamar's family and to all those who knew and loved him."

The death of Hunt, who is a member of eight different Hall of Fames including the NFL Hall of Fame in Canton, Ohio, not only has saddened Kansas City fans and Chiefs followers around the world, but it also has allowed those associated with the NFL and other major sports to recognized Hunt's role in creating a monster of a sports league.

Carl Peterson, general manager and Chiefs team president, let his emotions dictate his feelings for the man who hired him to come to Kansas City in 1988 to turn around a struggling franchise. With emotions evident during a Thursday afternoon press conference at Arrowhead Stadium, Peterson stated,

"Today, the Kansas City Chiefs, the National Football League and the city and community of Kansas City lost a special person in Lamar Hunt.

"Lamar was a visionary, a leader and uncommon man who had kind words for everyone. He was humble, selfless, extremely modest, an individual who made everyone he touch feel very good."

". . . Lamar Hunt helped changed the face and the image of Kansas City, Mo., and Kansas City, Kas."

Throughout America Thursday, sports leaders and figures remembered Hunt's tremendous leadership in the world of sports and American life.

NFL Commissioner Roger Goodell said, "Lamar Hunt was one of the greatest leaders and innovators in the history of sports. His vision transformed pro football and helped turn a regional sport into a national passion. Lamar created a model franchise in the Kansas City Chiefs, but he was always equally devoted to the best interests of the league and the game, from the AFL-NFL merger to the two-point conversion. His legacy is unmatched in sports and the NFL -- a pioneer, a founding father, and one of the most important architects in the history of our game."

Paul Tagliabue, former NFL commissioner said, "Lamar Hunt was a founding father of modern professional sports and a tremendous sports visionary and leader."

"I first met Lamar in 1969 and had the privilege of working closely with him on an extraordinary range of projects in a number of sports. He always led with vision, tenacity and humility. . . Above all else, he was intensely focused on the best interests of the fans -- especially his beloved Chiefs fans -- and on the collective interests of the league and of his fellow owners, no matter the sport. Norma and Lamar have always been among the most supportive friends and colleagues that Chan and I have had during our decades in the NFL."

As Tagliabue saw, "He was one of the most considerate, one of the most thoughtful and one of the most visionary people you could ever deal with."

Steve Perry, president and executive director of the Pro Football Hall of Fame, said, "Lamar Hunt's contributions to professional football and to the sports world are enormous and well-documented. . . He was also a very generous and civic minded individual. He has been a steadfast supporter of the Pro Football Hall of Fame and has served on its Board of Trustees since 1968. For all of us associated with the Pro Football Hall of Fame who knew him so well, we will most remember him as a friend and an advocate for, and shining example of, all that is good in sports."

Although Hunt is noted for his role in the creation of the American Football League which had eight members, it was Hunt who helped bring the two football leagues together. It was also Hunt, who took a struggling Dallas Texans football franchise from football-crazed Texas in 1963 to the Midwest and Kansas City.

Hunt's early Chiefs' squads had marginal success but the tide soon turned as the Chiefs of the late '60s and early 1970s brought most of the pride to the city.

Hunt's Chiefs played in the first two of four Super Bowls, losing to the Green Bay Packers, 35-10, in Super Bowl I in Los Angeles for the 1967 championship, and claiming a surprising victory over the heavily favored Minnesota Vikings, 23-7, for the 1969 championship in Super Bowl IV in New Orleans.

David Glass, owner of the Kansas City Royals, said, "He was a pioneer in the world of sports and business and a true gentleman. We enjoyed many years together as partners in the Kansas City sports scene and as neighbors at the Truman Sports Complex. Lamar's vision and influence really created the regional landscape for great teams and great fans."

A man who loved sports, particularly soccer which was Hunt's first love, the late Chiefs owner was also instrumental in developing a professional soccer league in America.

Although soccer is still considered an outsiders sport by some U.S. citizens, it was Hunt who helped bridge minds and develop plans for what is now a 13-team soccer league called Major League Soccer. Hunt was also the original owner of the Kansas City Wizards, which was recently sold to OnGoal, Inc., this year. Hunt's family also currently owns the Columbus Crew and the FC Dallas of the MLS, and his family also has financial ties with the Chicago Bulls of the NBA.

Hunt is also responsible for helping to bring several international exhibition soccer matchups, including three matches involving the United States Men's and Women's Soccer teams to Arrowhead Stadium.

"There quite simply has never been a more influential person in sports in the United States, and when it comes to soccer he was the pioneer, the innovator and the patriarch all rolled into one. And that statement was as true in 1966 as it is in 2006," said U.S. Soccer President Sunil Gulati.

Major League Soccer Commissioner Don Garber stated, "There is no doubt that MLS and the sport of soccer in America would not be where it is today with Lamar Hunt's passion, commitment and unrelenting love of the game. He dreamed more than 430 years ago that America could someday be a Soccer Nation. And he lived to see that dream come true."

Said Garber, "Everyone at Major League Soccer was fortunate to have the opportunity to rub shoulders with someone who had a hand in writing our history, and to work alongside a man whose humility, quiet confidence and commitment continue to serve as a lesson to us all."

As for his football resume, Hunt along with the late legendary coach and Hall of Famer Hank Stram, were also instrumental in recognizing the role of the black athlete in professional football.

Hunt's Chiefs, along with the Cleveland Browns and the Oakland Raiders, were some of the first professional football organizations to incorporate a large number of African American players into their systems.

During Kansas City's early years, the Chiefs had a roster full of some of the greatest African American football players of all time including Hall of Famers Bobby Bell, the late Buck Buchanan, Willie Lanier, and even current Chiefs Hall of Famers Otis Taylor, and other players like Curtis McClinton, Emmitt Thomas, Mack Lee Hill, Mike Garrett, Abner Haynes. Buchanan (Grambling State), Lanier (Morgan State), Thomas (Bishop College) and Taylor (Prairie View A&M) were the leaders among the many players that Hunt and Stram sought at historically black colleges and universities.

In fact, the Chiefs were considered along with the Cleveland Browns as the leaders in developing talent primarily from black colleges. The Chiefs were also one of the first franchises to hire an African American scout whose sole job was to scour talent at the black colleges.

Reproduced with permission of the copyright owner. Further reproduction prohibited without permission.